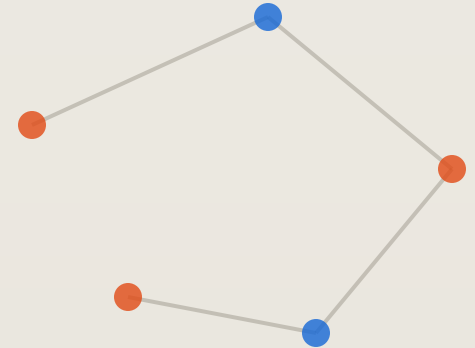


Your AI automation didn't fail.



You skipped a rung.

Five rungs. Most people jump.
The rung you skipped is the work you kept.

prompt · skill · loop · routine · agent team

Five rungs. Each one is work you stopped doing.

05 AGENT TEAM

maker split from checker

04 ROUTINE

the trigger is not you

03 LOOP

something else checks

02 SKILL

saved once, reused

01 PROMPT

you are the checker

more handed over →

Typed every time, then saved once.

01 PROMPT

You are the memory, the planner
and the checker. All of it.

| close the tab and it is gone

02 SKILL

Your rules written down once,
picked up every time they fit.

| no re-explaining it every Monday

A loop is not a prompt that repeats.

It has three parts a prompt does not.

VERIFIER

Something other than the model can reject bad output.

STATE

What is done, what failed, what is next. Tomorrow resumes.

STOP

Two exits: it succeeded, or eight tries and report.

Without a real check you do not have a loop. You have an agent **agreeing with itself on repeat.**

Off your machine. Then split in two.

04 ROUTINE

It runs on a schedule.
The trigger stops being you.

| close the laptop, it keeps going

05 AGENT TEAM

Roles, not one worker. The maker
is split from the checker.

| one agent grading itself is still rung 4

A rung only holds if the one below it is reliable.

So the order is not negotiable:

- 1 one manual run you trust
- 2 save it as a skill
- 3 wrap it in a loop with a gate
- 4 then put it on a schedule

Scheduling what you never made reliable by hand
is how automations burn money overnight.

One symptom. One next move.

RUNG 1

You retype the same context every session

→ save it as a skill, not an agent team

RUNG 2

Rules are saved, you still read every output

→ add a verifier, not a bigger model

RUNG 3

Bad output gets rejected, you still press go

→ put it on a schedule

RUNG 4

Runs without you, one agent grades itself

→ split the maker from the checker

NOT 5

You jumped straight to a team of agents

→ go back and earn rung 3 first

Every rung you climb is maintenance you cannot **walk away from.**

A program returns the same output forever.
An agent does not.

CLIMB PAST RUNG 2 ONLY IF ALL FOUR ARE TRUE

- ☐ the task repeats at least weekly
- ☐ something can reject bad output on its own
- ☐ the agent can do the work end to end
- ☐ done is objective, not a judgment call

Miss one and stay on the rung you are on.

Be honest about the rung you are on, not the one you talk about.

Which one did you try to skip?